



MICHAEL MAIER UND DIE FORMEN (AL)CHEMISCHEN WISSENS UM 1600

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Herausgegeben von
Simon Brandl und Volkhard Wels

HARRASSOWITZ VERLAG

Michael Maier und die Formen (al)chemischen Wissens um 1600

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Episteme in Bewegung

Beiträge zu einer transdisziplinären Wissensgeschichte

Herausgegeben von Gyburg Uhlmann
im Auftrag des Sonderforschungsbereichs 980
„Episteme in Bewegung.
Wissenstransfer von der Alten Welt
bis in die Frühe Neuzeit“

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Imago et error

Decrypting the allegorical images of Michael Maier's *Viatorium* (1618)

Sarah Lang

1 Introduction

Michael Maier's *Viatorium* is, in some ways, a curious tract. Originally published by Maier in Oppenheim in 1618 when he was employed at the court of Moritz of Hessen-Kassel, it was reprinted after the Thirty Years War in Rouen in 1651.¹ This indicates a continued interest in the contents of this tract which is relatively short for Maier's standards for non-ludic or pamphlet-type works and remains

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- 1 Research literature on the *Viatorium* remains scarce and superficial, but the following works have at least begun to address it: J.B. Craven: Count Michael Maier. Life and Writings. Reprint 2003. München 1910, p. 105–110; Bruce T. Moran: The Alchemical World of the German Court. Occult Philosophy and Chemical Medicine in the Circle of Moritz of Hessen. Princeton 1991, p. 104–105; Hereward Tilton: The Quest for the Phoenix. Spiritual Alchemy and Rosicrucianism in the Work of Count Michael Maier (1569–1622). Berlin, New York 2003, p. 199; Erik Leibenguth: Hermetische Philosophie des Frühbarock. Die *Cantilenae Intellectuales* Michael Maiers. Edition mit Übersetzung, Kommentar und Bio-Bibliographie. Tübingen 2002, p. 503f.; W.R. Newman: Newton the Alchemist: Science, Enigma, and the Quest for Nature's „Secret Fire“. Princeton 2018, p. 51–53, p. 62–63, p. 74f.; Sarah Lang: Michael Maier, *Viatorium*, hoc est, de monitibus planetarum septem seu metallorum, Oppenheim: Johann Theodor de Bry 1618, Exemplar Universitätsbibliothek der Goethe Universität Frankfurt, Slg. G. Freytag H 1329 und Signatur Bibliothek Senckenberg 8° R 523.670. In: Merian und die Bebilderung der Alchemie um 1600. Hg. v. Berit Wagner. Frankfurt/M. 2021. URL: <https://merian-alchemie.ub.uni-frankfurt.de/ausstellung/ii-alchemische-bildwelten/maier-viatorium-1618/> (last accessed 2023-09-03); Kristofer Schliephake: Merian, Titelblatt Maier, *Viatorium*, 1618. In: Merian und die Bebilderung der Alchemie um 1600. Hg. v. Berit Wagner. Frankfurt/M. 2021. URL: <https://merian-alchemie.ub.uni-frankfurt.de/ausstellung/ii-alchemische-bildwelten/titelblatt-merian-maier-viatorium-1618/> (last accessed 2023-09-03); Adam McLean: The *Viatorium* of Michael Maier. A 17th Century English Manuscript Translation Transcribed by Fiona Oliver and Voicu Ion Cristi. Ed. 2005 Glasgow provides an edition of a historical 17th-century translation of the *Viatorium* into English. However, this translation – like it is common with historical translations – is not all that reliable and tends to further obfuscate parts of the text which are difficult to understand. Thus, this book has to be used with caution. On problems in using historical translation in scholarship see Lothar Mundt: Empfehlungen zur Edition neulateinischer Texte. In: Probleme der Edition von Texten der Frühen Neuzeit. Beiträge zur Arbeitstagung der Kommission für die Edition von Texten der Frühen Neuzeit. Ed. by Lothar Mundt, Hans-Gert Roloff, a. Ulrich Seelbach. Tübingen 1992, p. 186–190. New research on the *Viatorium* and the chemical contexts for *Atalanta fugiens* is presented in the contribution by Rainer Werthmann in this volume. A German translation of the *Viatorium* is under preparation in a collaboration between Rainer Werthmann, Aaron Plattner and the author of this article.

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rather overlooked in the research literature on Maier to this day. The roughly 150-page treatise opens with a multitude of beautifully crafted admonitions to keep alchemical secrets, yet fashions itself as a clear guide for the perplexed, a didactic Ariadne's thread through the errors of chymistry. The book appeared in two editions, 1618 and 1651, and its seven chapters discuss the seven metals at varying lengths, beginning with the longest chapter by far concerning Mercurius and becoming briefer with each subsequent chapter. This essay aims to shed light on the function of the images in Michael Maier's *Viatorium*, which mark the end of the second subsection in every one of the seven chapters.

Maier's comments on secrecy and the contents of the *Viatorium* present a contradiction in themselves. For instance, the introductory poem (*epigramma authoris*) assures the reader that "the page shall not fool you [the reader] with questionable tricks". However, in the *praefatio ad lectores*, which directly follows this poem, Maier cites not one but two examples of mythological individuals who shared secrets they were not supposed to and paid the price for it. While this is undoubtedly a topical call to keep the alchemical secrets hidden, it is in stark contrast with the rest of Maier's work, which is written in relatively clear language. He avoids being highly allegorical but inserts a long excursus on an image towards the end of each chapter, demonstrating his mastery of alchemical encipherment techniques such as the heaping up of *Decknamen*, which W. Newman termed *parathesis*.

Michael Maier's paratextual rhetoric of secrecy in the front matter is a fascinating subject. However, it seems that this performance of secrecy has a different function than the emblematic images which conclude the second subchapter ("On the use of [philosophical metal] for Tincture"). Those, so this article shall argue, have a didactic function within Maier's otherwise quite clear manner of expression in the *Viatorium* (1618). After closer investigation, this argument might possibly be applied to other emblems of Maier in the future.²

The introductory matter of Maier's 1618 *Viatorium* (title page with the full title, author's epigram, introduction to the readers, and a chapter called *Tractatus divisio*, which ironically does not actually contain information on the contents of the chapters) is full of tropes. Many of them concern finding one's way, an obvious allusion to the title of the work *Viatorium*, the "travel guide" for those erring through the mysterious ways of chymistry. He often uses the Latin word *error* in this context, meaning an 'error', 'misstep', or 'misunderstanding'. This article will argue that clearing up common *errores* in the thinking of chymical beginners is a primary didactical principle Maier employs in the *Viatorium*.

2 The didactical structure of the *Viatorium*

It can be assumed that the intended audience for the *Viatorium* consists of beginners who wish to understand both the theory and practice of chymistry. While the emblematic images and allegories discussed in this article may be entertaining

2 See also the article by Rainer Werthmann in this volume.

enough, the rest of the chapters would likely be rather dull for readers who are not interested in or familiar with actual chemical experiment. It is probable that Maier wrote the *Viatorium* with its distinctive style to impress patrons who have a basic understanding of the subject matter but are not experts themselves. Maier takes care to present himself as a competent and experienced practitioner of the alchemical art who not only understands how processes are performed, but can also explain the theory of how they work. Throughout the *Viatorium*, Maier uses a number of recurring images, such as Ariadne's thread guiding through the labyrinth of the mines or the North Star as a navigational aid in the sea of chymical errors. This is not surprising, as he is famous for his erudite style rich in mythoalchemical imagery. These images illustrate the nature of his book as a travelogue, a guide for all those who become lost while journeying through the depths of chemistry. Maier provides a way out by thoroughly explaining the theory of the seven metals and debunking a number of conceptual errors that may have led his readers to their predicament. While Ariadne's thread symbolizes a way out for those who are lost, the allegories placed at the end of each chapter represent a chemical misunderstanding that Maier wishes to debunk. Emblems are some of Maier's favourite didactic devices.

Maier's self-fashioning in the *Viatorium* is that of an expert practitioner who, through his practical experience combined with a thorough theoretical understanding, is the most qualified person to teach chemistry. His book reads like a literature review, summarizing the most important information on each of the metals, as well as central intellectual frameworks, such as Aristotelian hylomorphism, elements, and Galenic humours, and combining them with his own alchemical experience and theory. However, it does not contain any recipes. Maier merely demonstrates theoretical and practical knowledge in both the pharmaceutical and medical application of alchemical remedies, as well as good knowledge of typical metallurgical processes and mining.

It is evident that Maier adopts a matter-of-fact writing style that is neutral and academic throughout the chapters. He plainly states that he will not discuss metaphorical substances or planets, but rather the metals as they are commonly known.³ Maier limits his elaborate use of mythoalchemy and allegory, which is probably his unique sales proposal within the alchemical tradition of his time, to their allocated space in the order of the *Viatorium*. Each chapter begins with a definition of the metal to be discussed and first notes its uses for making gold (*chryso-poeia*, *De I. usu ad aurum*), before elaborating on its uses for making tincture (*iatro-chemistry*, *De II. usu ad tincturam*) and explaining its uses in medicine (*De III. usu ad medicinam*). Maier's playful allegories are always placed at the end of the second subchapter on the use for making tincture, i.e. the alchemical *panacea* which is the goal of iatrochymistry, an alchemical tradition that focuses on using alchemy

3 Michael Maier: *Viatorium*. Oppenheim 1618, p. 44. See the full quote and translation of this text passage below.

for making remedies rather than gold-making. Although he uses some metaphors in his prose elsewhere whenever suitable, he restricts his secretive language and elaborate imagery to these images, which are each illustrated by a copper plate. They function as a relief from the more serious didactics in the form of a riddle.

Firstly, the beginning of the second chapter *On the Mountain of Saturnus* shall serve as a contrasting foil against which we can compare the relative secrecy versus openness of Maier's allegorical images. As an introduction to the contents to be discussed, Maier writes:

By Saturnus, I mean here neither the outmost planet of the universe nor the pagan God, so-to-say the forefather and first founder (about whom I talked enough in his place in my Hieroglyphics), but the metallic substance which is called by the name of lead and its minerals, like it is commonly understood.⁴

He is, thus, quite clear that he is not talking about either astrology or any other form of symbolism but rather about chemistry. He merely employs the name *Saturnus* (as opposed to *plumbum*) whenever he is talking about 'philosophical Saturnus', i.e. the concept of a metal, as opposed to the *communia*, and makes a point of sticking to his own terminology.

Each of the chapters features an image, a copperplate accompanied by explanatory text, reminiscent of Maier's famous emblem book, *Atalanta fugiens* (1617/18). The article by Rainer Werthmann in this volume demonstrates the explanatory interconnectedness of the emblematic images and riddles of *Atalanta* and *Viatorium*. They are interconnected in a way that the surprisingly deep chemical significations of some *Atalanta* emblems can only be fully understood by seeking out similar sections in the *Viatorium* where more chemical context is given to explain the possibility of a chemical interpretation of those *Atalanta* emblems beyond doubt. This somewhat odd but typical alchemical communicative behaviour is called *dispersio* or 'dispersion of knowledge' in the context of alchemical stylistic devices.⁵ The narrative text following each image is always constructed in a two-step structure and serves to clear up an alchemical error, as shall be demonstrated in the following. The error on the level of the *imago/pictura* or allegorical narrative stands for an error in the chemical interpretation regarding the metal discussed in each chapter. Maier's narrative usually consists of first describing the problem at hand with its error on the first layer and then going on to relate it to the metal

4 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 44: "Saturnum hic intellegimus non planetam illum mundi supremum, nec Deorum Ethnicorum quasi abavum & primum satorem (de quo in Hieroglyphicis nostris suo loco sat egimus) sed metallicam substantiam, quae plumbi vel ejus minerae, nomine appellatur, prout communiter recipitur." All translations, if not stated otherwise, are from the author, yet ultimately derive from interdisciplinary collaboration with Rainer Werthmann and Aaron Plattner.

5 William R. Newman: 'Decknamen' or Pseudochemical Language? Eirenaeus Philalethes and Carl Jung. In: *Revue d'histoire des Sciences* 49 (1996), p. 159–188, p. 187.

discussed in the chapter, usually using mythoalchemical allegory. Ultimately, this meaning is only partially explained by Maier, and the final solution of the riddle is left to the attentive reader. In the following, three of the seven allegorical images will be described and discussed chronologically in order of appearance in their respective chapters.

Throughout his work, Maier uses well-known fables of the Greco-Roman period as sources for his allegorical images.⁶ While not all emblems in *Atalanta fugiens* go back to classical sources, all the emblematic allegories of the *Viatorium* are rooted in Classical mythology and standard historiographical works such as Livy's *ab urbe condita* or Pliny the Elder's *naturalis historia*. While it ultimately remains unclear whether he drew directly from the antique sources or used the summaries of mythographers like Natale Conti, he does seem to cite Conti whenever he uses him in the 1614 *Arcana Arcanissima*. Of course, this is not definite proof that he does not use Conti in cases where he is not explicitly cited, but we may assume that Maier drew on classical sources directly. As a poet laureate, Maier probably prided himself on his direct knowledge of classical sources without having to go through a middleman. However, Maier's mythoalchemy goes beyond merely relating ancient fables. Since he believes them to contain the hidden chymical knowledge of the Ancients, he interprets them chemically, putting his own mythoalchemical spin on all of them. The goal of the following pages is to illustrate this on a selection of allegories from the *Viatorium*, which contains a total of seven images, one in each of the seven chapters.

3 Allegorical images in the *Viatorium*

3.1 *The Seven Gates of Thebes and the Viatorium device from the title copperplate (Mercurius)*

We begin our analysis with an unusual example of the puzzles in Maier's *Viatorium*. The distinctive nature of this first emblem can be partly attributed to the Mercurius chapter's peculiarity in the *Viatorium*. This chapter is the longest chapter of the *Viatorium*, comprising pages 14–43 and accounting for more than a fifth of the total 138-page 1618 edition, dominating the various prefaces and seven chapters that make up the *Viatorium*.⁷

In the first chapter, Maier illustrates, both figuratively and literally, the seven gates of Thebes in Boeotia. Mythologically, the city is said to have been founded by Cadmos.⁸ Maier emphasizes that chemists should refer to this Thebes rather

6 On Maier's mythoalchemy see Peter Forshaw: Michael Maier and Mythoalchemy. In Bilak & Nummedal (eds.): *Furnace & Fugue. A Digital Edition of Michael Maier's Atalanta fugiens* (1618) with Scholarly Commentary (2020). <https://furnaceandfugue.org/essays/forshaw/> (last accessed 2023-09-03).

7 There is a page numbering error in the final pages of the *Viatorium*: After page 136, the numbering jumps back to 135, so the final page (labeled 136 in the 1618 issue) is actually page 138.

8 The expression "Seven-Gated Thebes" goes back to Homer (Hom. Il. IV 406; Hom. Od. XI 263)

than the Egyptian city. He begins his allegory by relating the ancient myth in his own words:

At each of the gates stands a different symbolic statue. The highest tower, constructed from marble, features the symbol of a human (*homo*) and is located towards the sunfall of Aequinox (North West). The subsequent gate, overlooking the sunfall of winter solstice (West), displays a lamb (*agnus*). Facing Septentrio (North) is the third gate that showcases a dolphin (*delphinus*). The fourth gate, positioned towards the sunrise of the winter solstice (North East), corresponds to a bovine figure (*bos*). The fifth gate, facing the sunrise of Aequinox (East) exhibits a he-goat (*caper*). However, the labels in both the 1618 and 1651 editions erroneously say *cancer* instead of *caper*. Assuming this gate symbolizes Saturnus, *caper* would be the correct term. The sixth gate is adorned with a hound (*canis venaticus*) and points towards the sunrise of the summer solstice (South East). The image labels in both editions state *canis cacias*, likely equivalent to the Italian ‘cane da caccia’. The seventh and last gate faces the sunfall of the summer solstice and is decorated with a lion (*leo*). There is an eighth gate pointing towards midday (*meridies*, South) but it has been closed since ancient times and concealed behind a wall. Each respective gate was open only on a specific day of the week, and it was illegal to transport animals into the city through any other gate except for their proper one. When travelers initially encountered the city walls, they viewed a magnificent construction but found themselves confused about how to enter the city. As a result, they became very tired before ultimately discovering an entrance. Once an individual arrived from where the west wind Zephyrus blows, hoping to ascend to the castle but was disappointed. He retreated outside the walls to get a better overview. Whenever he arrived at a gate, he examined his *Viatorium* device, attempting to determine the most direct route to the fortress.⁹ What he could not know, however, and would learn only later is that the best way into the city is through the locked eighth gate. The next best is from where the northwest wind Corus blows (*leo*), then the one facing the sun fall of Aequinox (North West, *homo*). Whether he ultimately figured it out and succeeded in reaching the fortress, Maier dares not say,

where it is distinguished from the Egyptian “Hundred-Gated Thebes” (Hom. Il. IX 381–384). According to the founding myths of Thebes, the mythological Amphion and Zethus, twin sons of Zeus and Antiope, the daughter of the Boethian river god Asopus, built the gates while constructing the city’s fortification walls. Various historical sources, particularly drama works like Aeschylus’ *Seven Against Thebes*, describe each gate as defended by a specific mythological hero, although there is little agreement among different sources. The symbolic statues assigned by Maier to the gates do not correspond to either of the descriptions of the gates or the heroes’ shields. While Maier mostly refers to the Egyptian Thebes in his *Arcana Arcanissima*, he mentions Boeotic Thebes only a few times (Lib. 3, p. 162), and suggests that Cadmus was born there, contrary to the standard version of the myth that has him coming from Phoenician Tyros (Lib. 1, p. 44).

- 9 The fortress is Kadmeia, the acropolis of Ancient Thebes, which contains the seven gates discussed in the tale (Elektrai, Homoloides, Proitides, Ogygiai, Borraiai, Neistai, Hypsistai, Onkaiai), shields the acropolis from the lower city, which was, in turn, surrounded by another wall.

but he knows that the individual must have possessed the knowledge necessary to achieve it.

This first emblem of the *Viatorium* is perhaps the most perplexing of all. It appears to be a meta-reflection on Maier's work itself, the *Viatorium*, rather than a direct chemical allegory like the others, which function as reflective prompts to help digest the main points made in each chapter. This will be explained in more detail later.

The title page features a text area containing the full title and publication information at the center, framed by eight image regions. These regions mirror the eight gates of Thebes, of which only seven are actual gates, and the eighth corresponds to the *Viatorium* device.¹⁰ On the title page, this means that Maier's portrait is located at the top center, in which he holds a compass-like device, the *Viatorium*. The rest of the frame is read counter-clockwise: it displays the order of the chapters in a counterclockwise rotation, beginning with Mercurius in the top left corner, followed by Saturnus on the center-left level, then Iupiter below it. At the bottom of the frame, Venus is located in the lower left corner, facing Mars in the lower right corner. The mythological lovers are separated by a romantic water landscape with the outlines of city walls blurred in the distance, which functions as a background. Schliephake interprets the water landscape to symbolize the Ocean of errors that can only be surmounted by using one's *Viatorium* device.¹¹ However, since none of the other tropes from the full title or introductory matter have made it into the symbolism of the title page, it is more likely that this just represents one of Matthäus Merian's famous landscape etchings without necessarily any other added meaning beyond its ornamental value.¹² Above Mars, on the center-right level, is Luna, and the upper right corner is occupied by Sol.¹³

10 In the case of the first chapter's image, the 1651 Rouen edition's imitation of the original copper plate (which had probably been lost during the Thirty Years War) is not an exact copy. The later reprint has a somewhat simplified version of the original title page. A copy of the 1651 Rouen edition is available in the Internet Archive: https://archive.org/details/michaelis_majeriv00maie (last accessed 2023-09-03).

11 Schliephake: Merian (fn. 1), online.

12 Michael Gaudio: The Emblem in the Landscape. Matthäus Merian's Etchings for *Atalanta Fugiens*. In: Furnace and Fugue. A Digital Edition of Michael Maier's *Atalanta fugiens* (1618) with Scholarly Commentary (2020). <https://furnaceandfugue.org/essays/gaudio/> (last accessed 2023-09-03).

13 Instead of this ornate 1618 title page, the 1651 edition has a shorter title on the ornate copper plate, surrounded by the eight images, followed by a second title page that includes the full title separated by a compass, i.e. a *Viatorium* device, from the publication information at the bottom. The symbol for Mercury is at the center of the *Viatorium* device, and the other six symbols are arranged in a circle around it. However, this arrangement does not reflect the order of the chapters anymore, suggesting that the later editors did not understand or intentionally modified the likely intention reflected in the setup of the original copper plate. The surrounding circle shows symbols for Saturnus, Jupiter, Mars, Sol, Venus, and Luna, starting at the top right. This order does not correspond to either the *aurea catena* of metals symbolised by Maier in the arrangement of his chapters on each of the seven metals or the setup of the seven gates of Thebes in either the original 1618 edition or the 1651 update. Apart from being of lesser

The accompanying image to the Theben narrative in the Mercurius chapter seems to correspond vaguely to the layout of the title plate of *Viatorium* and shall thus be interpreted accordingly in the following. To make the connection, one must to flip the map of the seven gates of Thebes where the “best gate” at *Meridies* is located at the bottom center. This corresponds to the top center self-portrait of Maier holding his *Viatorium* device. Above and to the left of this portrait is the second best gate, *leo*, which corresponds to the top right corner Sol of the title page.

Each of the personifications is accompanied by some of the god’s traditional attributes, the astrological symbol for the respective planet, and one or two symbols for astrological signs. Not all twelve zodiac signs appear to be in their correct places, but this is the only astrological component in the whole of *Viatorium*.¹⁴ It has to be taken into account that his addition may have been made by the engraver Matthäus Merian the Elder, who may have had a certain degree of artistic freedom in creating this design. However, it would be wrong to assume that the *Viatorium* is an astroalchemical work. Not only does it not lend itself to astroalchemical interpretations, but Maier also explicitly states that he is not talking about planets.¹⁵

On the title plate, Mercurius has the symbol for Venus (♀, one stroke is missing, probably by accident), and is accompanied by *Aquarius* and *Gemini*. He carries his *caduceus* and wears his *petasus* helmet as attributes. Saturnus is shown with his astrological symbol (♄), a sickle showing him as Kronos (Κρόνος), god of the harvest in the Golden Age. He is likely accompanied by his children, whom he devoured in his myth. Beside him sits a Capricorn. Jupiter (♃) is depicted with a crown, sceptre, and his thunderbolt. He is standing on two fish (*Pisces*) to his right. To his left sits a *Sagittarius*. Venus (♀, unlike in the case of Mercury, the symbol is turned upside down here) holds a flaming heart and Cupid’s arrow. To her feet lie *Libra* and *Taurus*. Mars (♂) is shown with a sword and shield, to his feet lie *Scorpio* and *Aries*. Luna (☾) wears a moon diadem and holds a half-moon. To her feet crawls a *Cancer*. Sol (☉) holding a sun and scepter and wearing a crown, is accompanied by a lion (*Leo*).

In Maier’s seven gates of Thebes, the symbols correspond partially to the images of Maier’s title plate: The Maier portrait holding a *Viatorium* device corresponds to the eighth gate in the south. The South West gate with a lion corresponds to the top left of the title page when flipped, which is congruent with Sol. The West

quality, the personifications of the 1651 title plate differ from the 1618 one in one meaningful detail: the fish are missing from the Jupiter illustration.

- 14 For example, Sol is correctly associated with *Leo* and Luna *Cancer*, Mars with *Aries* and *Scorpio*; Venus with *Taurus* and *libra* and Jupiter with *Sagittarius* and *Pisces*. However, it is in the first two chapter personifications that discrepancies arise: Saturnus is accompanied by *Capricorn* and *Gemini*, instead of *Capricorn* and *Aquarius*. Mercurius is shown with *Aquarius* and *Gemini*, instead of *Gemini* and *Virgo*. The zodiac sign *Virgo* seems thus to be missing from the title plate.
- 15 Leibenguth agrees that Maier’s work cannot reasonably be interpreted as ‘astroalchemical’: Leibenguth: *Hermetische Philosophie* (fn. 1), p. 227–230. See also the Latin quote from the beginning of the Saturnus chapter discussed earlier.

door holds the lamb as its symbol, which would then signify Luna, alchemical silver. The North West gate's *homo* could then correspond to Mars and *sagittarius*. The North gate has the symbol of a dolphin, which was sometimes used in art to symbolize Venus's birth from water. However, the correspondence only partially makes sense from here. The next gate has a *bovis*, which is also aligned with Venus in the title plate as *Taurus*. Actually, the *bovis* symbol should match Jupiter. However, if one leaves the astrological symbols aside and looks towards mythology, Jupiter transformed into a bull to approach Europa (albeit this animal is called *taurus*, at least in the Ovidian rendering of the story, Ov. Met. 2, p. 833–875). The next symbol, *caper* (even if probably mistakenly labeled *cancer* in the *Mercurius* plate) matches Saturnus' affiliation with Capricorn. The hound or hunting dog, the symbol of the last gate in the South East, however, is traditionally associated with Hermes' half-sister, the hunting goddess Artemis, not Mercurius. As shown by this juxtaposition, there seems to be a definite partial overlap between the Thebes image and the title plate. Still, it is not conclusive, and the added interpretative benefit of this reading is, as of yet, unclear to the present author.

3.2 The dragon's blood (Saturnus)

In the chapter on Saturnus, Maier presents an allegorical narrative that provides an *aition* (a mythical origin story) for the alchemical concept of dragon's blood. He describes how a *draco* – the description makes it seem more snake-like than modern ideas of a typical dragon – lurks in the path to a waterhole frequented by an elephant. Returning from drinking, the elephant is described as “watered”. The *draco* now uses the opportunity to attack the large animal, binding itself around the elephant and drinking its blood. As the elephant dies, it falls down on the *draco* who is crushed to death, regurgitating the elephant's blood as it dies.

Because nothing is good entirely, a huge *draco* often crosses him, hostile and murderous. In order to cause damage to such an immense beast to whose strength it [the snake] is no match at all, it attacks him in an ambush, not daring to attack it openly (*aperto Marte*). Watching the path by which the watered elephant returns, the *draco* claims it where it is straightest, hidden down below until the elephant, swelling with water, approaches around whose feet and sinuous body it then binds itself, spilling [the elephant's] blood and drinking it up. At last, when the elephant's strength has waned, taking revenge for its own death, it kills the *draco* who, blood-saturated, lays curled up around him by breaking down to the floor with its whole weight; the *draco*, sure of its own victory, regurgitating and sprayed in [the elephant's] blood. Its blood is then called dragon's blood (even though it is rather part of the elephant), quite useful to medicine and other necessities of humankind. This snake whose blood is taken as philosophical medicine needs to be properly understood, that is not as something earthly taken from the ground, so that it is not wrongly substituted. It is of the kind

which is attributed to Saturn, to Apollo, to Aesculapius and Mercurius, which killed Cadmos' comrades and was killed by him, which guarded the Golden Fleece and the apples from the Garden of the Hesperides [...].¹⁶

Maier also mentions the allegory of the dragon and the elephant in *Atalanta fugiens'* Discursus XXV (p. 110). The fable goes back to Pliny the Elder's *Naturalis historia* (Plin. nat. VIII, 32–34 and XXXIII, 115–117). Pliny, too, relates the *aition* of the name 'dragon's blood', explaining that the Greeks used that term to refer to cinnabarite (HgS) or vermilion red. However, *minium* is not cinnabarite or vermilion, but rather red lead or triplumbic tetroxide (Pb₃O₄), as known to Vitruvius (Vitr. VII 8, *On vermilion and quicksilver*). Maier describes how to produce it in the Saturnus chapter but stresses that it is utterly useless for chrysopoeia.¹⁷

Maier goes on to point out that this blood is typically called 'dragon's blood' but as is evident from the story, it is actually the elephant's blood, and thus, most people are committing an error in making a wrong symbolic substitution. It is not, Maier stresses, something earthly taken from the ground, but that which is an attribute of Saturn, Apollo, Aesculapius and Mercurius. The same type of thing which was killed by Cadmos, guarded the Golden Fleece, and the apples from the Garden of the Hesperides. He then briefly explains this *parathesis* of alchemical *Decknamen*, saying things such as the friends of Cadmos being the same thing as the elephant that is killed by the *draco* and, in turn, killed by Cadmos like the dying elephant kills the *draco*.¹⁸ However, he does not truly explain the chemical con-

16 Maier: Viatorium (fn. 3), p. 55–56: "Cui, ut nihil est ab omni parte beatum, continuo se invidum et hostem internecinum draco praegrandis offert. Hic ut tam vastae beluae, cui viribus longè sit impar, damnum ingerat, non audens aperto Marte cum ea conflagere, rem ex insidiis aggreditur hoc modo. Observat quâ viâ elephas aquatu rediturus sit, eandem, ubi arctior est, praeoccupat, seseque inferiori loco abscondit, donec elephas aquis praetumidus accedat, cujus pedibus nexus et gyros suo corpore sinuoso injiciens sanguinem libat et ebibit. Tandem ubi viribus defecerit elephas, draconem circum sese in nodum reflexum, jam cruore saturatum, deque victoria contra hostem obtenta securum, suo pondere in terram corruens, ipsa morte vindictam sumens conterit et extinguit, omni regurgitante et offusso ejus sanguine, qui post DRACONIS (licet potior pars elephantis sit) dicitur, ad medicinam aliasque necessitates hominum non inutilis. Draconem hunc, cujus sanguis ad medicinam philosophicam assumitur, oportet quem probè agnoscere, ne terreum quid, seu ex terrae fundo depromptum, aut aliud haud conveniens in ejus locum substituat. Est autem ex eo genere, quod Saturno, Apollini, Aesculapio et Mercurio ascribitur, quod Cadmi socios interfecit, et ab eo interfectum, quod vellus aureum observavit, quod pomis aureis Hesperidum hortis invigilavit, [...]."

17 Maier: Viatorium (fn. 3), p. 47–48: "Ex qua operatione peracta tandem lythargyrium rufum vel subalbum, in igne vitrificatorium solummodò transfusionem habent, non aurum, à quo longissimè abest. Qui in initio vel post addiderunt acetum, fortè ad folvendum vel incaerandum, ut reciperet amissam humiditatem vel melius purgaretur à superveniente sulfure comburente, cerusam albiissimam quidem acceperunt, sed ad argentum et aurum omnino inutilem substantiam. Ex hac igni fortiori exposita minium, vel imbibitione cum urina vel cum aliis alii colores, non aurum nec argentum resultant."

18 Maier: Viatorium (fn. 3), p. 56: "Cadmi socios interfecit, quia idem sunt re, quod hic elephas, et à Cadmo interficitur vice versâ, quia elephas draconem moriens, occidit."

tent of this allegory but rather vaguely gestures to his Hieroglyphics, the *Arcana Arcanissima* (1614), in the tradition of *syncope*, the ellipsis of relevant information which is to be found elsewhere (a stylistic device called *dispersio*).

Is it possible to understand what Maier means by following his trail of references, gesturing to the *Arcana* and the comments he made previously in the Saturnus chapter? It will be argued here that we can, in fact, make sense of the allegory by following the way laid out for us by Maier. Solving this riddle is by no means simple or obvious, on the contrary: Maier does not provide a clear answer or give away the solution, and the fragments of information leading up to it need to be gathered with care. Presumably, this is Maier's didactic strategy: by presenting a difficult conundrum, he ensures that readers will engage with the concept long enough to genuinely comprehend it upon arriving at the conclusion. He also teaches them to work like a chymist, decode *Decknamen* and follow a trail of dispersed knowledge in which one book explains the other. Although it necessitates a certain level of patience, it is not possible to decode the riddle independently unless one has meticulously studied Maier's text.

Now what is that elusive interpretation? Let us return to what Maier's discussion of the *draco* and the elephant. Maier refers to common mercury as the *draco* in *Atalanta fugiens* XXV. In contrast to the earthy *draco*, the elephant had earlier been described suspiciously as 'watered' and is therefore to be connected to the element of water rather than earth. What Maier speaks of the *draco*, he probably means his concept of *Sulphur Auri*. In *Atalanta fugiens* emblem XXV, Maier writes that *dracones* always denote Mercurius.¹⁹ The image in the *Viatorium's* Saturnus chapter is not directly opposed to this, but the interpretation and subtextual meaning are somewhat more complex. In *Atalanta fugiens* XXV, Maier mentions that *dracones* are by nature enemies of elephants, yet there, he does not discuss dragon's blood and how this blood is actually the blood of the elephant, as he does in chapter two of the *Viatorium*.

Earlier in the Saturnus chapter, Maier had brought up his notion of *sulfur philosophicus* or *sulfur auri*. He also equates the *draco* Typhon with a sulfury substance in his *Arcana*.²⁰ Here, the elephant represents Philosophical Mercury which is why

19 Michael Maier: *Atalanta fugiens*. Oppenheim 1617/18, XXV, p. 110: "Mercurium enim draco semper denotat, sive ille sit fixus, sive volatilis."

20 Michael Maier: *Arcana Arcanissima*. London 1614, p. 81–82: "Draco, qui custodiae eorum praefectus est, ex Echidna et Typhone genitus, centum capitum traditur: Numerosa autem eorundem parentum soboles extare legitur; Eaque venenosa et monstrosa semper; Vt draco ad fontem Cadmi socijs lethalis, alius ad Vellus aureum, tertius hic ad mala Hesperidum, quartus ad Geryonis boves; Item Cerberus, Sphynx, Chimaera, et ejusmodi alia horrenda et multiformia monstra, de quibus suis locis: Typhon sulphureum et ardentem spiritum, Echidna aquosam et frigidam volubilem substantiam denotat; Ex his enim duobus minerarum diversae species pullulant, quae semper monstrorum nominibus propter naturae varietatem appellatae et descriptae ab antiquis fuerunt: De Dracone, vtpote de genere, quemadmodum et de loco natali malorum aureorum, ex his satis constat; nunc de specie tantarum arborum ejusque fructuum videbimus." Translation by Aaron Plattner (fn. 1): "The serpent presiding

the dragon's blood (which is actually the blood of the elephant) is Philosophical Mercury. A follower of the Mercurius sulfur theory of alchemy,²¹ Maier argues in the Saturnus chapter that lead has too much *sulfur Auri* to be used as a base for chrysopoeia, causing it to devour itself as well as its adjoint companion, (philosophical) mercury.²² "Truly, the substance of *plumbum* is corrupted very quickly in strong fire because it is the most adverse to its cold nature. The reason why lead is destroyed in fires is manifold: First and foremost because *sulfur comburens et combustibilis* (burning and combustible sulfur) is abundant in it, which ignites in very strong fire and consumes itself and the companion to which it is joined, that is mercury. This happens more or less with all imperfect metals but especially in lead because of its abundance [of *sulphur auri*]."²³ Maier stresses that in order to achieve gold through the alchemical art, one must recreate its perfect balance of qualities (hot, cold, moist and dry). However, this perfection inherent in gold is like one essence (as he says of Apollo in his *Arcana Arcanissima*) and cannot be produced from lead.²⁴ When lead burns, the surplus of *sulfur comburens et combustibilis* deprives its argent vive of all its radical moisture, and the experimenter ends

over their guard, begotten by Echidna and Typhon, allegedly had one hundred heads. But it is said that numerous children of the same parents still existed. They are said to be always poisonous and monstrous, like the dragon at the spring, which was fatal to Cadmus' companions, another at the golden fleece, a third here at the apples of the Hesperides, a fourth at the cattle of Geryones, and likewise the Cerberus, the Sphinx, the Chimera and other terrible and multiform monsters of this kind, of which (mention will be made) in the appropriate place. Typhon denotes a sulfurous and fiery exhalation, Echidna a watery and cold, unstable substance. From these two sprout various kinds of minerals which, because of their different natures, were always called and described by the ancients with the names of monsters. The background of the serpent, namely its origin, the how and the birthplace of the golden apples, are sufficiently established based on what has been said."

- 21 William R. Newman: Prinzipien. In: Claus Priesner and Karin Figala (eds.): Alchemie. Lexikon einer hermetischen Wissenschaft. München 1998, p. 288–289.
- 22 He uses different terms amongst which *sulfur Auri* or *sulfur combustibilis et comburens* to denote when he means the sulfuric principle as opposed to common sulfur.
- 23 Maier: Viatorium (fn. 3), p. 46: "Citissimè verò corrumpitur: plumbi substantia ab igne fortissimo, utpote ejus frigidae naturae adversissimo. Causa cur plumbum ignibus destruat, multiplex. Prima, et praecipua, quod abundet sulfure illo communi combustibili et comburente, quod cum vehementiori igne inflammetur, consumit suum subjectum seu socium sibi adjunctum, nempe argentum vivum, idque contingit vel magis vel minus in omnibus imperfectis, praecipuè in plumbo propter ejus abundantiam."
- 24 Maier: Arcana Arcanissima (fn. 20), p. 204–205: "Haec satis elucidare possunt quis sit Apollo, nempe Sol noster, quis Draco, serpens aut Python, nempe illa aqua faetida quae putrescit; Id clarissime Lullius Theor: Test. C. 10. testatur: Aer hac, inquit, ratione allegoricè oportet dicere, quod magnus Draco de quatuor est Elementis, et non intellectu literali, quia sit terra, aër, aqua vel ignis, sed sola natura est et una quae continet in se naturam et proprietatem 4. Elementorum." Translation by Aaron Plattner (fn. 1): "Thus they can sufficiently illuminate who is Apollo, of course our Sol, and who is the serpent or creeper or python, of course that stinking water that rots. The clearest testimony is given by (ps.-)Lull in his Testamentum, Theorica, c. 10. He says: *And for this reason, it is necessary to say allegorically that the great serpent is of the four elements, and not in the literal sense of being earth, air, water, or fire, but there is only one nature, which contains in itself the essence and characteristics of the four elements.*" Maier references part one of the pseudo-Lullian

up with a glass-like substance. No union or reconciliation of the qualities (*aequatio contrarium qualitatum*) is achieved, and it is not possible to separate out the philosophical mercury from lead, which could later be used as a base substance for gold-making.²⁵ In the nature of lead, the two principles are so deeply intertwined that they cannot be separated – like the elephant and the snake of the allegory, both die in their union and nothing useful is produced.²⁶ Maier concedes that “if truly *Mercurius plumbi* could be coagulated by tincture of *sulfur auri*, stable and acting, meaning hot and dry, then, without doubt, other metals could also be transmuted into perfect gold” but it cannot, as *Mercurius plumbi* will only degenerate gold into useless earth, as all who have experimented it will certainly be aware.²⁷

Thus, we may conclude that the *draco* represents lead’s *sulfur auri* and the elephant represents *Mercurius plumbi*. According to Maier, Saturnus has an overbearing amount of *sulfur auri*, which causes it (the snake or *sulphur auri*) to consume itself and its companion (the elephant or *Mercurius plumbi*). Consequently, it is impossible to extract philosophical mercury from Saturnus. In any case, in Maier’s narrative dragon’s blood becomes a symbol for the interplay between mercury and sulfur, which is at the heart of alchemical mercury-sulfur theory to which Maier subscribes. Unlike the *draco* that relates to Apollo, this fight between the *draco* and the elephant denotes the concord of the two diametrical opposites of alchemy, Philosophical Mercurius and Philosophical Sulfur. Or rather, in the case of Saturnus, the failure to reach a harmonic balance when attempting to unite the quarreling principles starting from Saturnus.

Testamentum (~1330), called *Theorica*. Jennifer M. Rampling: *The Experimental Fire: Inventing English Alchemy, 1300–1700* (Chicago 2020), p. 43–51.

- 25 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 49: “Idcirco causam evidentiore trademus cur non hoc modo aequatio fiat in aurum, si calcinetur plumbum quocunque igne, vel lento vel forti, cum vel absque additione rei alterius, sed in substantiam ab auro remotissimam abeat. Causas corruptionis plumbi in igne jam ante exposuimus, quae tum sunt verissimae, hinc ejus argentum vivum omni humiditate radicali spoliatur et vitro fit proximum. Aequatio autem contrarium qualitatum non accidit, quia non fit totalis separatio sulfuris comburentis, sed saltem vnus partis, cum forte duae ejus partes maneant in composito, nec sint separabiles, quia ob terrestreitatem aliquid fixitatis in se habent, non quidem aureae sed terreae viscosae, mox vitrificandae. Et quo major pars ejus sulfuris sit combusta, eo magis exiccatum et depravatum est argentum vivum: Vnde hoc ex sua natura in terram mutatum, à faecibus sulfuris facile in vitrum reducitur, quod est omnium compositorum ultimum. Quod si per artificium ignis vel alium modum concedatur ex plumbo posse omne sulfur segregari, neque tum ille Mercurius purus in aurum aequari posset, quomodocumque tractetur.”
- 26 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 51: “Causa verò, cur argentum vivum nec ascendere, nec descendere potuit, relictis suis faecibus sulfureis et terrestribus, haec est: Quia in fundo naturae haec duo arctius colligata sunt, quàm ut artificio, quod igne perficitur, separentur ab invicem. Vnde medio aliquo abstersivo vel separativo extraneo egent, vel argenti vivi homogeneo colectivo, eoque vel crudo vel maturo, et agente.”
- 27 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 51: “Ne quis autem existimet, Mercurium plumbi qualicunque modo coagulatum in aurum nobilitari, cum contrarium reipsa experietur, nempe ipsum in terram inutilem degenerare. Quod si verò à sulfure auri fixo et agente, hoc est, calido et sicco, tingente Mercurius plumbi coaguletur, nullum est dubium ex eo, ut et alias aurum perfectissimum fieri posse, de quo hic non est disserendi propositum.”

As Newman already hints at in his definition of the stylistic device called *parathesis*, we have, in essence, learned nothing new from it. It is a visualized summary of Maier's main arguments in the Saturnus chapter. Its contents are about chemistry and serve a didactic function rather than mere embellishment. The *parathesis* does not provide much added benefit but helps to illustrate further, perhaps to help readers jog their memory.

The purpose of juxtaposing multiple names for the same thing is to bewilder the reader and possibly weed out those unworthy readers who did not comprehend the message. After narrating the allegory, Maier proceeds to explain that the common thread among all the mythological individuals mentioned is the *draco*. However, unlike what the usual open style of the *Viatorium* would suggest, he does not go on to explain what any of this means. Instead, he expects readers to unriddle the chemical significance in self-study. An attentive reader may note that the *draco* most certainly refers to his concept of *sulfur auri* which he had introduced throughout the Saturnus chapter. Following a classical Mercurius Sulfur theory of alchemical generation, Maier believes that each metal contains two principles, Mercurius and Sulfur, which need to be combined to complete the alchemical work. This, however, is not an easy task, as Mercurius is the principle of volatility which always seeks to escape the alchemical union. As in the title story of *Atalanta fugiens*, where Atalanta represents philosophical mercury fleeing Hippomenes, i.e. philosophical sulfur, the alchemist requires a tactic like the golden apples of the story to deceive volatile mercury into the chemical union. However, as we may infer from this image, Maier does not regard Saturnus as a suitable starting point.

However, none of this information can be deduced solely from the *parathesis*. The reader must undertake the task of comparing and reconciling the differing descriptions of *dracones* found in the *Arcana Arcanissima* with the contents of the *Viatorium's* Saturnus chapter until one book can help explain the other.

Nevertheless, this stylistic device has a *raison d'être* beyond mere embellishment. The purpose of the *Sanguinis draconis descriptio* is most likely to encourage readers to reflect on the previous chapter's contents again and engage in deep meditation. It presents a different epistemic approach to the information presented and also serves as a mnemotechnical aid. Additionally, it teaches Maier's students the skill of decrypting the secretive stylistic devices of the alchemical tradition using a relatively straightforward example.²⁸ Newman argues that demonstrating one's ability to write and decode complicated alchemical language, and therefore showcasing the adept's hermeneutic skill, served to establish credibility in an alchemist's practical skills, claim authority, and emphasize one's rightful place in the tradition of older alchemists. Newman writes:

28 'Straightforward' because, unlike in other alchemical writings, the answers can be found within the same chapter even if the answers may seem elusive at first.

Alchemical writers delighted in announcing that they were going to explain a riddle – only to give the answer in the form of a conundrum. [...] But there is another element that the reader was meant to derive from his alchemical sources. This was the aura of authority that a contemporary figurative text acquired by employing the metaphors utilized by older authors.²⁹

This is certainly true of Maier's *parathesis* as well: It not only serves to teach his readers hermeneutical skill, but also serves to show off his abilities as a masterful alchemical expert. Consequently, a skilled chymist is, among other things, a "scholar trained in the tropological interpretation of texts" who operates within the constraints of the very specific exegetical tradition of alchemy.³⁰

3.3 Mucius Scaevola kills a slave instead of the king (Mars)

In the chapter on Mars, Maier tells the story of the Roman legendary hero Mucius Scaevola (incorrectly named 'Mutius' by Maier), who left the besieged Rome to kill its Etruscan oppressor Porsenna and free the rightful king Tarquinius.³¹ Once in Porsenna's military camp, he kills someone dressed in purpur whom he takes to be the king. However, he has mistakenly identified a slave for the king. Threatened by the real king, Scaevola willingly holds his right hand, which had committed the murder, into the fire because restoring his honour is more important to him than his body. Porsenna was allegedly so impressed by this act of bravery that he withdrew his forces from Rome and made peace with the Romans, rendering Scaevola one of the central legendary heroes of early Rome. Maier concludes from this story that a good chymist should be ambidextrous and able to identify the king by more than the red colour of his clothes. He should kill him not through violence but through sweet water, like Barbarossa, the red-bearded king, died in water where he was washed and then covered in *mumia*, as befits a king.

The red colour is central to the allegory. Iron(III)-oxide is likely the most common colour pigment. Red made from iron oxide was called 'Tizian red' which is close to the bluish hue of gold ruby. This colour was interpreted by alchemists and chemists as a natural step in the process of moving towards the achievement of the philosopher's stone due to its symbolic significance.³² However, Maier criticizes

29 Newman: Decknamen (fn. 5), p. 164.

30 Newman: Decknamen (fn. 5), p. 159–188, p. 188.

31 The legend of Gaius Mucius Scaevola has a prominent place in Livy's history of Rome, *Ab urbe condita* (II 12, 1–13.5), and can also be found in Dionysius of Halicarnassus' *Roman Antiquities*, a Greek work that relates Roman history from then conquered Greece's perspective (V 27–30). However, it is unlikely that Maier used Dionysius as a source because the latter calls the hero Cordus rather than Mucius Scaevola and, in general, was a much less widely known and esteemed historiographer than Livy.

32 On the appreciation of blood red colour in alchemy see Claus Priesner: Blut (p. 83); alchemy was, in many ways, the art of dying colours, see Lawrence Principe: *Anima solis* (p. 48–49); on colours in alchemy see Claus Priesner: *Farben* (p. 131–133). All articles in: Claus Priesner and Karin Figala (eds.): *Alchemie. Lexikon einer hermetischen Wissenschaft*. München 1998.

the credulity of those who rely solely on looks when he writes: “Our king, after all, is sufficiently discernible from a servant, not only by his purpur robes but also his golden crown and his body’s most elegant decorum. He should not be killed by any absent mind or the right hand of some Scaevola but by an ambidextrous artifex.”³³ Colours are a significant topic in alchemy and this allegory summarizes Maier’s stance on how to use them wisely (or not) and how they can lead to errors in judgement.

4 Conclusion

Atalanta fugiens is undoubtedly Maier’s most well-researched work.³⁴ Yet because Maier’s emblems are so cryptic, they are hard to understand without additional context. Fortunately, there are numerous other publications by Maier which seem promising for shedding light on his allegories. One of them is his 1618 tract, *Viatorium*. Nevertheless, as this article has demonstrated, the *Viatorium* is an intriguing resource for interpreting Maier’s branch of alchemical didactics as well. He characterizes his work as didactic in the title and title plate and himself as a teacher and experienced guide in the texts of the front matter.

In the title of the work, Michael Maier characterizes his *Viatorium* as a useful and lucid treatise that is supposed to serve as a guide for those lost in chemical errors. To illustrate this, he follows up with a triad of metaphorical guides: a herma statue (“index mercurialis”) providing directions at crossroads, Ariadne’s thread guiding through labyrinths (and, as Maier notes in his *praefatio*, through the mines)³⁵ and the North Star (Cynosura) guiding those erring at sea. The book is intended for rational seekers of truth who are searching for the panacea (*alexicum*) of the red stone, i.e. the philosopher’s stone, which, according to Maier, is concealed in the mountains and the goal of every physician’s quest for knowledge:

Viatorium of Michael Maierus. That is on the mountains of the seven planets or metals; A treatise both useful and clear, which, like a mercurial index [probably: herma statue] at crossroads where three roads meet or Ariadne’s thread in a labyrinth, or Cynosura [North Star] in the vast ocean

See also Rainer Werthmann: Das Rot aus dem Gold – das Gold aus dem Rot. Glauber und das Goldrubinglas. In Stephanie Nomayo (ed.): Johann Rudolph Glauber. Alchemistische Denkweise, neue Forschungsergebnisse und Spuren in Kitzingen. Kitzingen am Main 2011, 259–276.

33 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 93–94: “Nam Rex noster satis digno scitur pro servo ab eoque non solum purpurâ, sed coronâ aureâ, et corporis decore ornatissimo secernitur, qui non aberrante mente aut dextra à Scaevola quodam, sed ambidextro artifice occidi debet, [...]”

34 On *Atalanta fugiens* (choice): Helena de Jong: Michael Maiers’s *Atalanta Fugiens*. Sources of an Alchemical Book of Emblems. Lake Worth 1969 (Reprint: Newburyport/MA 2002); Volkhard Wels: Poetischer Hermetismus. Michael Maiers *Atalanta Fugiens* (1617/18). In: Konzepte des Hermetismus in der Literatur der Frühen Neuzeit. Ed. by Peter-André Alt a. Volkhard Wels. Göttingen 2010, p. 149–194; Tara Nummedal and Donna Bilak (eds): *Furnace & Fugue. A Digital Edition of Michael Maier’s Atalanta fugiens* (1618) with Scholarly Commentary (2020). <https://furnaceandfugue.org/> (last accessed 2023-09-03).

35 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn. 3), p. 9.

of chymical errors, anybody who is rational, a lover of truth may use for investigating that universal remedy [Alexiacum] of the red stone which is hidden in the mountains and desired by all physicians.³⁶

Metaphorically, this pertains to the alchemical knowledge that Maier shares becoming fixed in his (guide) book, which shall serve as a *Viatorium* device, as depicted on the top of *Viatorium*'s engraved title page, that can be used for future reference, providing a stable, lasting vessel to the knowledge. The images towards the end of each chapter have a special place in Maier's didactic approach. They are undoubtedly intended in a similar way as modern textbooks feature a list of review questions, to verify if the reader has mastered the contents of the previous chapter. In the case of the alchemical tradition, Maier's images serve the additional purpose of teaching the reader how to decode typical alchemical stylistic devices, such as his use of mythoalchemy. Thus, they serve a didactic function beyond mere embellishment and actively contribute to the didactic purpose of Maier's guidebook for those lost in a sea of chymical errors. Ultimately, we have to situate Maier's *Viatorium* between the didactic tradition of emblems and the performative rhetoric of secrecy that functions as a sales proposal in the alchemical texts and 'books of secrets'.

36 Maier: *Viatorium* (fn.3), title page: "MICHAELIS MAJERI VIATORIVM. hoc est, DE MONTIBUS PLANETARVM septem seu Metallorum; TRACTATVS tam utilis, quàm perspicuus, quo, ut Indice Mercuriali in trivijs, vel Ariadne filio in Labyrintho; seu Cynosura in Oceano Chymicorum errorum immenso, quilibet rationalis, veritatis amans, ad illum, qui in montibus sese abdidit DE Rubra-petra Alexiacum, omnibus Medicis desideratum, investigandum, uti poterit." A historical translation of this passage can be found in: McLean: *Viatorium* (fn. 1), p. 5. Historical translations are problematic to use in scholarship as the concept of what a translation should look like in early modern times does not match up to our modern scholarly expectations. Thus, historical translations have to be used with great caution and understood as the often quite liberal renderings they are, cf. Mundt: *Empfehlungen zur Edition* (fn. 1).